



Leading from the front: Sadio Mane (centre) lifts Senegal's second AFCON trophy. GETTY IMAGES

Triumph amid turmoil

From contentious calls to Senegal's dramatic title win after a mid-game walkout, AFCON 2025 was **pure theatre.**

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Controversies, poignant fandom and finally the roar of the Teranga Lions — the Africa Cup of Nations (AFCON) 2025 saw football transcend beyond sport; it was cinema.

Even before the tournament began, five-time AFCON champion Cameroon announced two separate squads — one by Marc Brys (appointed coach by Cameroon's Sports Minister) and another by David Pagou (appointed coach by Cameroon's FA).

The latter, without key players like Andre Onana, Vincent Aboubakar and Eric Maxim Choupo-Moting, was ultimately finalised.

Then came the refereeing disputes.

Benin was left frustrated against DR Congo when a potential penalty wasn't given as the VAR stopped working, while spot kicks were controversially denied to South Africa against Egypt or to Cameroon against Morocco.

The worst came in the final: Congolese referee Jean-Jacques Ndala gave Morocco a penalty, one that Senegal felt was given unfairly. As a protest, almost all players of the squad walked off the field, creating pandemonium at the Prince Moulay Abdellah Stadium.

Sadio Mane, Senegal's highest goalscorer, however, stayed on the field and sought counsel from AFCON-winning manager (1988) Claude Le Roy, the grand old man of African football. "He came to me and asked me what I would have done if I were in his place? I answered, I would have continued playing." He told Canal Plus. "I explained to Mane that the result was not yet decided (score was 0-0), then he went to bring his teammates back onto the field," he explained.

Senegal's players eventually returned, with Edouard Mendy then saving Brahmin Diaz's attempt from the spot. Minutes later, Pape Gueye struck a stunner to clinch the title for Teranga Lions.

From the chaos of abandonment to the glory of Teranga Lions, Senegal completed its redemption arc in one match. But the mismanagement left the door open for numerous questions on refereeing and readiness for a country — Morocco — that will co-host the 2030 FIFA World Cup.

AFCON's biggest achievement, however, was the fanaticism of thousands of people, who thronged to the stadiums, wearing masks, face paints and bearing national flags. Over 700,000 fans attended the group stages of the tournament alone, compared to 643,000 in the previous edition.

Moroccan fans, who had painted Qatar red with their flags during the 2022 World Cup, left no stone unturned to cheer for their country on home soil, recording the highest average fan attendance at the tournament, at 62,185.

But one of the most iconic images of the tournament was that of Michel Nkuka Mboladinga (**left**). The Congolese superfan stood on a pedestal with his right arm raised, impersonating Patrice Lumumba, the first Prime Minister of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, who stood for independence and paid for it with his life.

AFCON 2025 might not have had the cleanest version of football, but it encapsulated everything that sport heals: crisis, politics and hatred. And that, alone, is enough to deem the tournament a success.



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